

Audio jargon – demystified

"The latest high-impedance, low-sensitivity headphones under review were difficult to drive and necessitated an amp, but the sound signature was devoid of any colouration; neither bright nor warm, just neutral. The soundstaging is phenomenal and the entire frequency range is reproduced accurately from deep lows to extreme highs".

Did the preceding paragraph make sense to you? If sentences like these have been driving you up the wall ever since you can remember, read on to quickly understand audiophile terminology used in most reviews and write-ups.

Impedance: Impedance is the resistance against electrical flow. In the world of audio gear too, it means the same thing. Measured in ohms, it basically denotes how difficult it is to move the speaker's driver. By and large, high-impedance systems require more power to drive them, hence requiring an amplifier to enhance the signal.

Sensitivity: Another often seen term in the specifications of audio systems (speakers or headphones) is sensitivity. Sensitivity is the sound pressure level measurement (loudness) taken at a distance of one metre by applying one watt of power. Therefore all other things being constant a high-sensitivity audio system will require less power to sound as loud.

Frequency response: The entire audio signal coming out of a speaker belongs to different frequencies of the audio spectrum. The audio range of speaker systems (and the human ear) lies in the range of 20 Hz to 20,000 Hz or thereabouts. The frequency response of a speaker system denotes the range of such frequencies that it can reproduce effectively.

Highs: This term denotes the reproduction of frequencies belonging to the higher end of the audio spectrum. Generally, anything above 5,000 Hz is classified as high frequency. Certain instruments and vocals pitches – such as violins, female vocals and cymbals – belong to this higher side. If a headphone has good "highs" it will be able to reproduce these sounds well.

Lows: Bass notes or "boom" like sounds belong to the lower frequencies in the audio spectrum. These are frequencies measuring 20 Hz to 350 Hz. Kick drums, bass guitar and baritone vocals are low frequency or lows.

Mids: All sounds in the range of 350 Hz to 5,000 Hz. This range brings the overall feel of the audio track. What people commonly refer to as treble starts from mids and extends into the highs.

Neutral: A neutral sound signature is one that reproduces all frequency ranges appropriately

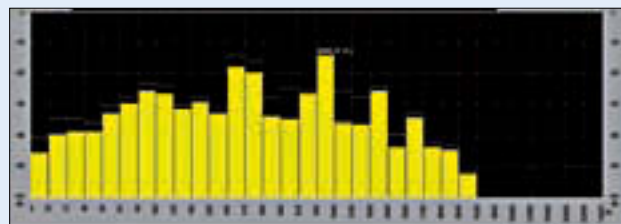
without emphasis on any particular range like bass, mids or highs. Such audio systems are considered true to source.

Warm: A warm sounding speaker or headphone is one that is a little partial towards the mid frequencies. The sound produced hence is a little mellow and soft.

Bright: A bright sound signature is one that is produced by audio systems with a proclivity for high frequencies. The sound produced as a result is vibrant and hence called bright.

Colouration: Any system in the audio chain that adds emphasis on a particular frequency range is said to produce coloured sound. And the process is called colouration. Colouration may sound pleasing but it's a deviation from accuracy.

Soundstaging: This is a pure listening term and the efficacy of it can be debated. Basically, it denotes the perception of depth and positioning of particular sources of sounds such as instruments and vocalists. Some headphones and speaker systems are thought to reproduce or create the illusion



Fiddle around with various frequencies in your media player's Equaliser to understand lows, mids and highs

of distinct positions of sources within the spacial environment.

Dynamic range: Defined as the ratio of the loudest and softest sound that an audio system can reproduce without distortion. Again the ratio is measured in decibels.

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